

5.2 Download Managers

Downloading can be achieved by a browser, but a download manager is a dedicated application that offers a few extras. A download manager has the capability to find and automatically link to other servers offering the same file; this allows the download to continue even if the original source were to break down. The ability to schedule a download and shut down the PC after the download is complete is another feature.

All download managers offer the following, so these would be conspicuous only by their absence.

- Browser integration / clipboard scan: this allows for the download manager to take over downloading jobs when any download link is clicked in the browser or copied to the clipboard.
- Speed monitor: Some form of indication of the speed at which the download is progressing.
- Bandwidth control: Limiting download speeds so that concurrent browsing is not adversely affected.
- Simultaneous connections: Creating more than one connection to the source server in order to increase download speeds.
- Mirror search: Finding other sites offering the same file and sharing the bandwidth load across servers. This also improves download speeds.
- Download basket: An area on the screen that can initiate a download when any link is copied onto it. This is of use when browser integration does not apply to the user's preferred browser.
- Preview : Allows the user to view the file's contents before it is completely downloaded. Very useful.
- Scheduling: Start downloads at a particular time; if required, can dial up the Net connection, and shut down the system or close the Net connection when the download is complete.

5.2.1 Free Download Manager

(www.freedownloadmanager.org)

Besides the usual download manager features, FDM integrates a user review system. People downloading a file can offer a review of